

COMM1140: Collaboration and Innovation in Business

L. Cheung

June 9, 2026

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0.1 Course Overview

Weekly Structure

- Complete pre-workshop module online (40-60mins)
- Read workshop agenda
- Go to live workshop

Assessment Structure

Assessment Task	Collab.	Weighting	Due Date
Creativity and Innovation in Everyday Life	Individual	15%	11 June @ 3pm (Week 2)
Problem Definition and Project Plan	Group	20%	Week 5 in class
Solution Delivery	Group	30%	Week 10 in class
The Redesign Challenge	Individual	35%	13 August @ 3pm (Week 11)

More assessment information can be found in the official guide.

Chapter 1

Innovation & Creativity

1.1 Creativity vs. Innovation

Creativity is the process of generating original ideas and exploring possibilities. These ideas never have to be implemented, rather the value of creativity comes from the act of thinking differently. Innovation is where creative ideas are turned into something useful, practical, and impactful, ie. making ideas real.

Example

In the 1960s, Spencer Silver invented a low-tack, reusable adhesive, however he didn't execute the idea into a product. It took another individual, Art Fry, to realise that the adhesive could be used to attach temporary notes to his hymn book, refining the concept into a useful product, Post-it notes.

1.1.1 Process of Idea to Innovation

1. **Capture** the creative idea. Write it down, sketch it, or record in whatever format is most accessible.
2. **Explore** the idea by developing it and finding out who it would benefit and what problem(s) would it solve.
3. **Evaluate** the feasibility of the idea to ensure that it can actually be made, delivered, and sustained.
4. **Prototype** on a small-scale, or release a pilot to receive feedback and continue refining.
5. **Iterate** through solutions based on feedback and testing to optimise usability.
6. **Launch** the product, starting small and gradually scaling up, and most importantly continuing to innovate the idea.
7. **Reflect** on the process, what worked and didn't, and what could be applied to future ideas

1.1.2 Key Takeaways

- Creativity is about generating ideas; innovation is about making ideas real.
- Ideas can be creative even if they are never implemented.
- Innovation can become repetitive without creativity.
- Turning an idea into innovation is iterative, using capture → explore → feasibility → prototype/test → iterate → launch/scale → reflect.

1.2 Convergent vs. Divergent Thinking

When solving challenging problems, people process potential solutions differently and can be broadly categorised as either convergent or divergent thinkers. Divergent thinking is about exploring as many possible ideas by valuing novelty and originality, while suspending judgement. At this stage, there are no 'bad' ideas. In contrast, convergent thinking is about narrowing down a specific solution. This involves evaluating ideas against a clear criteria, prioritising quality and feasibility, and aiming for the best possible solution. Neither of these methods are superior over the other, however to come to the true best solution, both processes must be applied.

Example

In 2007, the founders of Airbnb were broke and needed money for rent. Their first move was to brainstorm as many possibilities to make money quickly, without limiting themselves to conventional solutions. They came up with the idea of renting air mattresses on their apartment floor, with some accommodation services.

Initially they utilised divergent thinking to generate an unconventional idea that would make them money. Then, they switched their thinking to try and scale the idea into a larger business. Convergent thinking allowed them to decide what features would stay and which would go, shaping their side hustle into a multi-billion-dollar company.

1.2.1 Key Takeaways

- Divergent thinking generates lots of options and suspends judgement.
- Convergent thinking narrows down using criteria like feasibility and quality.
- Teams need both, used intentionally, to avoid either endless ideas or premature shutdown.

1.3 Creative Confidence

Creative confidence is the ability to be comfortable with generating ideas, and the belief that you can take action on them. It is less about being naturally creative, and more about having the confidence to take the first step. More specifically, it is about trusting yourself to experiment, even when the outcome is uncertain.

1. Try testing out an idea in a low-stakes environment. Rather than waiting for the 'perfect' idea, test something small and quick. Gather initial feedback from peers which will uncover new perspectives much more valuable than endless planning.
2. Treat mistakes as learning opportunities. Creative confidence grows when it is understood that a setback is a small part of the larger process of developing an idea.
3. Notice small wins on your part. Realise that your own actions have contributed to something to reinforce your belief that you can act on your ideas.

Example

Continuing the story of Airbnb, the initial business model seemed too risky and potentially dangerous. However, it was only through practical testing that the value of the idea could be realised and extended. They initially kept the experiments very small, refining their idea in one apartment before expanding.

1.3.1 Why Innovation Doesn't Work

It is important to understand that innovation involves risk, and that not every idea succeeds. These failures are all part of the process.

Example

Google Glass were wearable smart glasses with a heads-up display, camera, and voice controls. The product was designed to be successor to the mobile phone, providing hands-free access to information, notifications, and media.

The product failed since it performed poorly in daily use, with the camera making other people uncomfortable, leading to privacy concerns. It also had a high price tag for a product that felt like a beta.

Instead of marketing it as a replacement to the phone, it could have been designed as an accessory at a lower price. Furthermore, the product could have included an obvious recording light to address privacy concerns.

1.3.2 Key Takeaways

- Creative confidence is about believing you can act on ideas and create change.
- It grows through practice: low-stakes experiments, learning from mistakes, and noticing small wins.
- Setbacks can be treated as learning opportunities that shape iteration.

Chapter 2

Collaboration

2.1 Team Process Efficacy

The ability of a team is not based solely on individual ability, but in the way they plan, communicate, coordinate, respond to conflict, and adapt together. This confidence is the foundation for effective collaboration. Team process efficacy builds on self-efficacy and team efficacy. Self-efficacy is the belief in your own ability to succeed at a particular task. Team efficacy is similar, but at the group level. It is the belief that the entire team is capable of succeeding of a goal. Team process efficacy takes this even further, where each group member believes in the planning, communication, coordination, etc. that will allow the group to succeed.

- **Planning**

- Setting clear goals
- Defining tasks
- Creating timelines
- Consider creating roles such as lead facilitator that can guide the team

- **Communication**

- Sharing updates, ideas, or concerns
- Being open, clear, and ensuring everyone is on the same page

- **Coordination**

- Making sure tasks are aligned and resources are used efficiently
- Avoiding duplicated work

- **Conflict management**

- Don't avoid discussing disagreements
- Teams should aim to handle conflict constructively
- Address issues openly, find solutions and maintain respect

- **Adaptability**

- Teams with high process efficacy are able to adjust quickly when plans need to change
- Making sure that the team is resilient

Example

The Slack messaging platform started as a failed video game. The game didn't work out, but the team had strong process efficacy and trusted their ability to plan, communicate, and adapt. They repurposed the original game's chat into Slack, creating one of the most successful communication platforms.

2.1.1 Key Takeaways

- Team process efficacy is confidence in how a team works together, not just confidence in individual ability.
- String team processes include planning, communicating, coordinating, conflict management, and adaptability.
- Process confidence develops through early wins, clear roles, psychological safety, and regular feedback loops.
- Strong teamwork depends on how a group works through challenge, not only on the final result.
- Different roles within a team support process efficacy in different ways.

2.2 Lencioni's 5 Dysfunctions

The success of a teams depend on foundations that support trust, challenge, accountability, and shared focus. Patrick Lencioni studied why teams fail and identified five common dysfunctions that derailed teamwork. These are shown in a pyramid, where each dysfunction builds on the one beneath it. (Results → Accountability → Commitment → Conflict → Trust).

- Absence of trust
 - Occurs when team members aren't comfortable with being vulnerable, admitting mistakes, asking for help, or sharing uncertainty
 - Building trust early sets the stage for open collaboration
- Fear of conflict
 - Teams that avoid disagreement often settle for safe or mediocre ideas instead of tackling tough issues
 - A healthy debate can lead to better problem solving and more creativity
- Lack of commitment
 - When people don't feel heard, they may agree outwardly but fail to fully support decisions
 - Clear decisions and buy-in from everyone ensures continual progress is made
- Avoidance of accountability
 - With no commitment, team members hesitate to hold each other responsible
 - Openly checking in and giving constructive feedback maintains a fair work distribution and keeps the project on track
- Inattention to results
 - Success should be measured by the team's outcome, not by individual contribution
 - Focusing on shared results ensures a cohesive, high-quality project

Example

The most visible dysfunction is an absence of trust. It is clear that the group have different ideas, however each team member is unable to constructively comment and build on their peer's work. Overall, this creates a general sense of hostility, restricting each individual and most crucially the progress of the team.

Another dysfunction present is a fear of conflict. One of the group members does not contribute at all during the meeting, due to the other members harmfully criticizing the work of their peer.

2.2.1 Key Takeaways

- Team dysfunctions often build on one another rather than appearing in isolation.
- Absence of trust weakens the foundation for open collaboration.
- Fear of conflict can stop teams from addressing important issues directly.
- Commitment and accountability become harder when people do not feel heard or included.
- Shared results remain strongest when teams focus on collective goals rather than individual priorities.

2.3 Courageous Conversations

Some problems require someone to name what is happening, ask better questions, and reopen a conversation that has become difficult. The focus is to address tension early, rather than let it affect the outcome.

In certain situations of tension in can feel easier to stay in silence rather than address the issue. To communicate clearly about the problem, the four C's can be used.

- **Clarity** - Be clear about the intent and the issue. Understand what you want to address and why it matters, so the conversation stays focused.
- **Curiosity** - Ask questions and understand the team member's perspective.
- **Compassion** - Lead with empathy and emotional intelligence. Consider the feeling of team members and approach the conversation with kindness.
- **Courage** - Have the confidence to say what needs to be said, kindly and honestly.

Difficult conversations are often easier when they begin well, with a clear purpose so that the discussion stays grounded.

1. Set the right intention, focus on improving the team or solving the problem rather than concentrating on blame.
2. Speak from your own perspective using "I" statements to express concerns and feelings without attacking others.
3. Acknowledge the difficulty and tension of the conversation.
4. Focus on behaviour rather than the person, addressing actions rather than the character.
5. Ask open questions and invite others to contribute to encourage discussion and collaboration.
6. Suggest a path forward and conclude with a constructive solutions

2.3.1 Key Takeaways

- Courageous conversations help teams address issues before they become harder to resolve.
- The 4 C's provide a practical way to approach difficult discussions.
- Productive conversations focus on behaviour, not personal attack.
- Open questions help keep the exchange collaborative rather than defensive.
- A clear next step matters if the conversation is going to lead to change.

2.4 Leadership

In collaborative work, leadership often appears in smaller decisions and actions rather than formal authority. Effective teams rotate leadership depending on what's needed. Being a good leader means developing specific skills including:

- Active listening
- Communication clarity
- Conflict navigation
- Decision making
- Accountability

Leadership can be classified under four different styles that each have strong suits and drawbacks with specific use cases. The first is **directive** leadership, where someone provides clear instructions, sets priorities, and makes decisions, especially useful when a team needs structure or quick action. **Facilitative** leadership encourages participation and maintains active listening. **Supportive** leadership is a style that focuses on helping team members succeed individually, offering guidance, assistance, or encouragement when it is needed. Finally, **visionary** leadership is where someone inspires the team with a clear long term goal or direction.

Example

Google's culture encourages shared leadership, where team members step into different leadership styles depending on the task. The flexibility within a team to switch to different leadership styles is one reason behind Google team's high performance.

2.4.1 Key Takeaways

- Leadership in collaboration is not limited to one formal role.
- Different moments may call for directive, facilitative, supportive, or visionary leadership.
- Leadership skills such as listening, clarity, conflict navigation, decision making, and accountability strengthen teamwork.
- Self-awareness helps you recognise both your strengths and the areas you want to develop.
- Peer support can help turn leadership reflection into practical growth.

2.5 Project Management

Project management helps turn broad intentions into clearer steps. It helps teams stay aligned, visible, and responsive as the project evolves.

1. Define a clear goal
2. Break the goal into bite-sized tasks
3. Assign who does what, and by when
4. Track progress through regular check-ins
5. Adjust as you go

2.5.1 Key Takeaways

- Project management helps teams move from broad ideas to clearer action.
- Strong project work depends on clear goals, visible tasks, assigned accountability, regular check-ins, and flexibility.
- Stand-ups help teams keep progress visible and surface blockers early.
- Miro supports shared planning, evidence gathering, and weekly contribution across the team.
- A strong Solution Plan shows a credible process for developing and testing a solution, not only a final answer.